

Form Shadow vs Cast Shadow

Two fundamentally different types of shadow

Understanding the difference between form shadows and cast shadows is essential to drawing light convincingly. They behave differently, look different, and serve different functions in a drawing.

KEY CONCEPTS

Form Shadow

Form shadow (also called core shadow or attached shadow) is the area of a form that doesn't receive the light source. It is attached to the form and describes its volume. Form shadows have soft, gradual edges. They reveal the 3D shape of the object.

Cast Shadow

A cast shadow is created when a form blocks light from reaching another surface. It is cast by the object onto the ground, wall, or another surface. Cast shadows have harder, more defined edges. They reveal the direction of the light source.

Edge Comparison

Form shadow edges: soft and gradual, because light wraps around curved surfaces. Cast shadow edges: sharper (but not perfectly hard), because they're projected from a point light source. The closer the shadow to the casting object, the harder the edge.

Drawing Both

Identify which type of shadow you're looking at before drawing. Ask: is this where the form curves away from the light, or is this a projected shadow? Draw form shadows with gradients; draw cast shadows as flat shapes with defined edges.

PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Set up a lamp and a simple object (sphere, cup). Identify and draw the form shadow and cast shadow separately.
2. Copy a master drawing and label every shadow as 'form' or 'cast'.
3. Draw an egg with form shadow only (no cast shadow). Then draw the cast shadow only.